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MISSION IMPOSSIBLE

Khrushchev's letters to Castro failed to produce the result that the Soviet leader hoped for. The stubborn Castro stuck to his guns and refused to sanction the Khrushchev-Kennedy deal. Khrushchev, who so far had been playing bad cop, decided that he needed a good cop as well. He found one in Anastas Mikoyan, the only Presidium member who had objected to the deployment of nuclear arms on Cuba and who tried to stop the nuclear-armed Soviet submarines from coming to the island. Khrushchev wanted Mikoyan to go to Cuba and improve Soviet-Cuban relations. "I proposed that Mikoyan be dispatched to Cuba," recalled Khrushchev later. "Having known Mikoyan for many years, I considered that his diplomatic qualities would be useful in this case. His nerves are good; he is calm and can repeat one and the same argumentation without raising his voice. That is very important, especially in negotiations with such a fiery man as Fidel."[1]

Mikoyan remembered Khrushchev approaching him after receiving Alekseev's report on his meeting with Castro on October 29. "Look, he